

The Otacon Engine

A small, reusable, in-house 2D game engine — architecture and usage manual

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Chapter 1

What Otacon is

Otacon is a small 2D game engine, built as a static library (`src/engine/`, namespace `otacon`). It is deliberately **game-agnostic**: it knows nothing about any particular game. Three games ship in this repository — *Canabalt* (`src/game/canabalt/`), the Chromium *T-Rex runner* (`src/game/dino/`) and *Flappy Bird* (`src/game/flappy/`) — and each links the same unchanged library, talking to it only through public interfaces. They differ in almost every way a game can: 480×320 / 600×150 / 288×512 logical resolutions, a scrolling follow camera versus a fixed one, a ported generator versus an original one. A fourth game would be one more `IGame` and one more CMake target; nothing in `src/engine/` would move. The golden rule of the layout is: **engine code never mentions the game, and game code never mentions GLFW / OpenGL / Vulkan / CoreAudio**. Everything crosses that boundary through four seams: `IGame`, `IWindow`, `IRenderer` and `IAudio`.

1.1 Philosophy

- **In-house subsystems.** Math (with a fixed-point scalar), an n -dimensional vector library, a memory manager, time management, a debug runtime, the OpenGL function loader, and even the PNG and CAF asset decoders are written from scratch. The only third-party code is the window library (GLFW or SDL2), fetched automatically.
- **Pluggable backends.** The graphics backend (legacy OpenGL, modern OpenGL, Vulkan) and the window backend (GLFW, SDL2) are chosen by a single config flag and selected at compile time — nothing above the platform layer changes.
- **Verifiable.** The renderers are held to a byte-identical contract: every backend draws the same deterministic frame to the same pixels (proven by SHA-256). See Chapter 13.

Chapter 2

Building the engine

The engine is built as part of the project’s CMake build; there is no separate “install”. A game executable links the `otacon` static-library target.

```
cmake -S . -B build          # first configure fetches the window library
cmake --build build -j8      # builds libotacon.a + the game exes
```

2.1 Compile-time configuration

All compile-time choices live in `config/build.cfg`; edit a value and re-run CMake (it reconfigures automatically when the file changes). Any key can also be overridden per-configure, e.g. `-DGRAPHICS_BACKEND=VULKAN`.

Key	Values	Meaning
GRAPHICS_BACKEND	GL_LEGACY / GL_MODERN / VULKAN	Renderer pipeline
WINDOW_BACKEND	GLFW / SDL2	Window / input / context library
SCALAR_TYPE	FLOAT / FIXED	Simulation number type
MEMORY_TRACKING	ON / OFF	Allocation tracking + leak report
DEBUG_RUNTIME	ON / OFF	Runtime debug views

2.2 Source layout

```
src/engine/      # ---- Otacon engine (static lib 'otacon') ----
  core/math/     #   Fixed (Q16.16), Scalar (float|fixed), Vector, Rect,
                  #   Random, Noise, Ease
  core/memory/   #   Tracked heap + Arena + Pool allocators
  core/time/     #   Clock + TimeManager (variable/fixed timestep)
  core/debug/    #   DebugRuntime (runtime view switching)
  asset/         #   In-house PNG decode/encode + CAF audio decode
  audio/         #   IAudio seam, software Mixer, CoreAudio / null backend
  platform/     #   IWindow seam; glfw/ and sdl2/ backends
  render/        #   IRenderer seam; gl_modern/ gl_legacy/ vulkan/
  scene/         #   Entity, Node, Scene, Camera, Collision, Emitter,
                  #   TileMap, Animator, Verlet, PathFinder, Steering,
                  #   SpatialGrid
```

```
App.cpp IGame.hpp #    Engine runtime + the game contract

src/game/          # ---- games on the engine (canabalt, dino, flappy) ----
src/samples/       # ---- fifteen engine samples (exe 'samples') ----
tests/smoke.cpp    # ---- headless engine self-tests ----
```

Chapter 3

The four seams

3.1 IGame — the game contract

A game is one object implementing `IGame`. The engine's `App` owns the window, renderer, audio device, timing and debug runtime, and drives the game:

```
struct GameContext {           // handed to the game once, at init
    IRenderer*   renderer;     IWindow* window;  IAudio* audio;
    DebugRuntime* debug;       int logicalW, logicalH; const char* assetDir;
};
class IGame {
    virtual void init(GameContext&) = 0;
    virtual void handleInput(const InputFrame&) = 0;    // edges + held state
    virtual void update(Real dt) = 0;                  // one simulation step
    virtual void render(IRenderer&, const DebugRuntime&) = 0;
    virtual void shutdown() {}                          // free GPU/audio handles
    virtual Color clearColor() const; virtual const char* title() const = 0;
};
```

`App::run()` is the main loop: poll input, step the simulation (zero or more fixed steps, or a clamped variable step), then render. The game is handed the renderer to draw with and the `DebugRuntime` so it can honour the clean-play / overlay state.

3.2 IWindow — window, input, context

`createWindow(cfg)` returns the compiled-in backend (GLFW or SDL2). The window exposes a uniform `InputFrame` (level-triggered `held[]` and edge-triggered `pressed[]` arrays keyed by an `Action` enum, plus normalised mouse position and the drag button), the GL context plumbing (`makeContextCurrent` / `swapBuffers` / `glProcAddress`) and the Vulkan plumbing (`vulkanInstanceExtensions` / `createVulkanSurface`). **Both backends are complete** and interchangeable; selecting one is a config flag.

3.3 IRenderer — drawing

See Chapter 5. A backend implements only triangle submission, the texture entry points and the frame lifecycle; all shapes are tessellated once in the shared `IRenderer` base, so every backend

draws identical geometry. Anything beyond that is an *optional capability* a backend may decline — see `supportsShaders()` in Chapter 11.

3.4 IAudio — sound

`createAudio()` returns the platform audio device (CoreAudio on macOS, a silent stub elsewhere); it never returns null, so game code is unchanged when no device is available. The game decodes its sounds in-house and uploads PCM with `createSound`, then fires one-shots with `play` and background music with `playMusic`. See Chapter 9.

Chapter 4

Writing a game

A minimal game is an `IGame` that draws something each frame:

```
class MyGame : public otacon::IGame {
    otacon::IRenderer* r_ = nullptr;
    void init(otacon::GameContext& ctx) override { r_ = ctx.renderer; }
    void handleInput(const otacon::InputFrame& in) override {
        if (in.isPressed(otacon::Action::Jump)) { /* ... */ }
    }
    void update(otacon::Real dt) override { /* advance simulation */ }
    void render(otacon::IRenderer& r, const otacon::DebugRuntime&) override {
        r.fillRect(100, 100, 64, 64, otacon::Color::rgb(0xf0c020));
    }
    const char* title() const override { return "My Game"; }
};
```

`main()` creates the `App`, the game, and runs:

```
otacon::App app;  MyGame game;
if (app.init(cfg, &game, assetDir)) app.run();
app.shutdown();
```

Chapter 5

The drawing API

The renderer works in a fixed **logical** coordinate space — 480×320 by default, origin top-left, y downward — and each backend applies its own projection to clip space. Colours are straight-alpha RGBA. The public primitives:

Call	Draws
<code>fillRect(x,y,w,h,color)</code>	a filled axis-aligned rectangle
<code>fillRotatedRect(cx,cy,w,h,deg,color)</code>	a rectangle rotated about its centre
<code>drawRectOutline(x,y,w,h,color,thick)</code>	a rectangle outline
<code>drawLine(x0,y0,x1,y1,color,thick)</code>	a thick line segment
<code>drawImage(tex,x,y,w,h,u0,v0,u1,v1,tint)</code>	a texture sub-rect into a dest rect
<code>drawImageRotated(tex,cx,cy,w,h,deg,uv,tint)</code>	a rotated textured quad
<code>drawText(text,x,y,scale,color)</code>	a string in the built-in 3×5 bitmap font

Textures are created from a decoded `Image` with `createTexture(img, repeat)` (nearest filtering, for crisp pixel art) and freed with `destroyTexture`. `updateTexture(tex, w, h, rgba)` replaces an existing texture's pixels at the same extent: it is the upload path for anything rasterised on the CPU each frame, and re-using the texture object avoids churning a GPU allocation every frame.

The cross-backend contract: a backend implements only `submitTriangles` (solid) and `submitTextured`, the texture entry points, and `beginFrame/endFrame`. Every shape above — rectangles, oriented lines, outlines, the bitmap font — is tessellated to triangles once, in the shared base class, so all backends rasterise byte-for-byte identical geometry.

Chapter 6

The scene system

The engine offers a small scene graph so rendering lives in one place — “the Scene renders the tree, nothing draws on the side.”

- **Entity** — simulation / collision data: position, size, velocity, acceleration, drag, the **solid/fixed/moves** flags, a **scrollFactor** for parallax, and an optional texture/colour for the entity draw layer. **updateMotion** integrates it.
- **Node** — a scene-tree element with **update(dt,cam)** and **render(r,cam)**; concrete nodes are particle emitters, sprite drawers, facade renderers, UI. A node may also override **renderColliders** (debug) and is skipped when **!visible**.
- **Scene** — owns the camera, an ordered entity draw layer (rebuilt each frame by the game), a backdrop node list (drawn *before* the entities, for the farthest parallax), and the main node list (drawn after). It ticks and renders the whole tree, then the debug overlays.
- **Camera** — a faithful flixel follow camera: centres a target, lerps the scroll, clamps to bounds, and projects world to screen through each entity’s **scrollFactor** (**screenPoint**). Also hosts the decaying screen-quake.
- **Collision** — flixel’s swept-AABB separation (**solveX** then **solveY**) with the same direction bookkeeping and extent rejection that avoids tunnelling.
- **Emitter** — a particle emitter (a **Node**) with a fixed pool, burst and continuous modes, gravity/drag/spin, and an optional sprite sheet so particles can be solid quads or textured frames.

Chapter 7

Core subsystems

7.1 Math and the pluggable scalar

`Real` is the engine number type. With `SCALAR_TYPE=FLOAT` it is an IEEE float (and reproduces the reference game bit-for-bit). With `FIXED` it becomes `Fixed`, an in-house *Q16.16* fixed-point type — a performance/determinism teaching point. (*Q16.16* saturates near ± 32768 , so an endless runner's world-*x* eventually overflows; that is itself the lesson about range.) Vectors (`Vector.cpp`) are templated on the scalar and explicitly instantiated for 2, 3 and 4 dimensions.

7.2 Memory manager

`core/memory` provides three classic allocators: a **tracked heap** (records every live block with size/tag/call-site and prints leaks at exit), a linear **Arena** (bump-pointer, reset per frame) and a fixed-size **Pool** (free-list, $O(1)$, zero fragmentation). Global `new/delete` are intentionally *not* overridden, so third-party allocations stay separate.

7.3 Time

`TimeManager` turns wall-clock time into the per-frame `dt`. The *variable* policy reproduces flixel exactly (`dt = now - last`, clamped to `maxElapsed = 1/20 s`); the *fixed* policy banks real time and emits whole fixed steps for frame-rate-independent determinism. It also drives the time scale used by the slow-mo / fast-forward debug control.

7.4 Simulation, AI and procedural helpers

Beyond `Entity` and the AABB solver, the scene layer carries the subsystems a 2D game reaches for: `SpatialGrid` (a uniform-grid broad phase, so collision need not be $O(n^2)$), `Verlet` (position-based dynamics for ropes, bridges and cloth), `PathFinder` (A* over a `TileMap`, with the heuristic exposed as the knob it really is), `Steering` (flocking plus seek/flee/arrive), `TileMap` and `Animator`. `core/math` adds `Random`, `Noise` and `Ease`.

`Random` is worth singling out. Before it existed, fifteen separate places in this project had each written their own linear congruential generator, two of them inside the engine. A generator here is a value rather than a global, so two systems can neither perturb each other's stream nor be made

irreproducible by the order they happen to run in — which is why the camera’s quake keeps a private one, a cosmetic shake having no business shifting the stream a level generator reads.

7.5 Debug runtime

`DebugRuntime` holds independently toggleable views (colliders, camera focus, parallax bands, grid, wireframe, velocities, HUD) plus pause/step and curated presets. Because the views are plain state read by the engine each frame, every backend gets identical debug visualisation for free. A single “UI hidden” flag gives clean-play (and is what `--capture` uses for deterministic frames).

Chapter 8

In-house asset decoders

8.1 PNG (`asset/Png.cpp`, `Inflate.cpp`)

Rather than link an image library, the engine decodes PNGs itself. `Inflate.cpp` is a from-scratch DEFLATE decompressor (RFC 1951) with its own bit reader, canonical Huffman decoder and LZ77 window, wrapped for zlib streams (RFC 1950). `Png.cpp` parses the chunk list (IHDR/PLTE/tRNS/IDAT/IEND), inflates, undoes the per-scanline filters (None/Sub/Up/Average/Paeth) and expands grayscale / RGB / palette+tRNS / RGBA into straight RGBA8. `PngWrite.cpp` is a matching encoder (valid PNG via stored/uncompressed DEFLATE blocks — no compressor needed) used for screenshots and the cross-backend diff.

8.2 CAF audio (`asset/Caf.cpp`)

`loadCaf` parses the (big-endian) Core Audio Format container — the `desc` chunk for the format, the `data` chunk for the samples — and decodes LPCM of any width/endianness into interleaved float in $[-1, 1]$ as an `AudioClip`. (Sounds in the reference game ship as 22050 Hz mono 16-bit LPCM.)

Chapter 9

Audio

The **IAudio** device owns an in-house software **Mixer** and a thin platform output. The mixer holds the uploaded sounds and a pool of one-shot voices plus one looping music voice, sums them into an interleaved stereo float buffer, applies master + per-voice gain and a soft clamp, and resamples on upload so the real-time render path never converts rates. A short mutex guards the voice list between the game thread (**play**) and the audio thread (**render**). The **CoreAudio** backend drives a `DefaultOutput AudioUnit` whose render callback pulls from the mixer; the **null** backend (non-Apple) accepts everything and stays silent. This is the only OS-specific audio code — exactly as GLFW is the only OS-specific window code.

Chapter 10

Graphics backends

10.1 The cross-backend contract

Every backend implements only triangle rasterisation plus the frame lifecycle. The contract:

- **Coordinates:** logical 480×320 , origin top-left, y down; each backend applies its own orthographic projection.
- **Blending:** straight alpha, `SRC_ALPHA / ONE_MINUS_SRC_ALPHA`.
- **Primitive:** triangle lists only; no backend-specific shapes.
- **Capabilities:** anything a backend cannot do is a question it is asked, never an assumption. `supportsShaders()` is the only one so far, and whatever is built on it must also work without it, so no screen becomes reachable on some backends and not others.

10.2 Per-backend notes

- **GL Legacy (2.1).** `glOrtho` + immediate-mode `glBegin/glColor/glVertex`; a compatibility context, no loader needed. Fixed-function throughout, so there is no programmable stage at all and `supportsShaders()` is false.
- **GL Modern (core 3.3).** A streamed VBO/VAO and a small vertex/fragment shader pair (the vertex shader does the logical→clip projection); needs a core, forward-compatible context and a function loader — shipped in-house in `gl_modern/GLLoader` (no GLAD/GLEW). The only backend with a reachable programmable stage, so it is the one where `supportsShaders()` is true and user fragment effects compile.
- **Vulkan.** A full implementation: instance (MoltenVK portability), device, swapchain, render pass, solid + textured pipelines from embedded SPIR-V, per-frame dynamic vertex buffers, staging-buffer texture uploads, and per-frame/per-image synchronisation. Key difference, handled in the shader: Vulkan clip space already has y pointing down, so it does *not* flip y as the GL shaders do. Validation-clean. Shaders are pre-compiled to SPIR-V and embedded at build time, so there is no runtime compiler and `supportsShaders()` is false; `updateTexture` is supported, via a staging buffer and a one-time command per upload.

Vulkan on macOS uses MoltenVK via the Homebrew loader; launch through `tools/run.sh` (it sets `DYLD_FALLBACK_LIBRARY_PATH` and `VK_ICD_FILENAMES`). It takes the executable to launch — `canabalt` (the default), `dino`, `flappy` or `samples` — so `tools/run.sh samples` is how the sample gallery is run on this backend.

Chapter 11

Samples

Fifteen sample screens (`src/samples/`, executable `samples`) exercise the engine on its own. They link `otacon` and nothing else, and generate every texture they use in code — a sample that borrowed a game’s art would mean a seam had leaked. One gallery object hosts them all, so adding a sample is one `.cpp` plus one row in `Registry.cpp`.

11.1 Per-pixel work and the shader seam

Two samples (2D lighting, and the shader playground) need per-fragment control, which sits awkwardly against the cross-backend contract: only the modern OpenGL backend has a reachable programmable stage. The engine therefore offers both halves and lets a sample choose:

- `updateTexture(tex, w, h, rgba)` re-uploads an existing texture’s pixels. A sample shades a buffer in plain C++ and pushes it once per frame. This works on every backend, GL legacy included.
- `createEffect(fragmentSrc, log, logSize)` compiles a user fragment shader, with `useEffect` and `setEffectUniform` to drive it. The engine keeps the vertex stage so the projection stays identical. `supportsShaders()` reports whether the backend can do this at all: true for GL modern, false for GL legacy (fixed-function) and for Vulkan (pre-built SPIR-V, no runtime compiler).

Every sample that uses an effect also carries the CPU path, so no sample is backend-exclusive and Chapter 13’s contract still holds everywhere.

Chapter 12

Debug & dev tools

These are engine-level and work in any game (state shown in the HUD when visible):

- **Perf + memory overlay (H)**. Frame-time graph (60/30 fps lines), live draw-call/vertex counts read from the renderer, and the memory manager's live/peak bytes — all backend-agnostic.
- **Time scale (+/-)**. Scales the *input* time $0.1\times..4\times$, so the fixed-timestep `dt` is unchanged and slow-mo keeps determinism.
- **Screenshots (F12) + capture**. The renderer reads the framebuffer back and writes it through the in-house PNG encoder. `--capture <png> --frames N` renders N deterministic frames (UI hidden) and quits — used by `tools/backend-diff.sh`.
- **Clean play (`)**. Hides all dev UI at once.

Chapter 13

Verification

The renderers are held to the byte-identical contract by `tools/backend-diff.sh`, which renders the same deterministic frame in each graphics backend and compares the PNGs. With both window backends in play, the full matrix — $\{\text{GLFW}, \text{SDL2}\} \times \{\text{GL_MODERN}, \text{GL_LEGACY}, \text{VULKAN}\}$ — produces **the same SHA-256 across all six combinations**: the rigorous proof that neither the window seam nor the graphics seam perturbs a single pixel. The headless `otacon_smoke` target additionally unit-tests the integrator, collision, the emitter, the fixed-point math, the PNG/-CAF decoders and the audio mixer.